

I have two דברי תורה for שמיני עצרת and שמחת תורה, brought down in a ספר called צלוחא דאברהם. It's based on the תפילות of a certain R' Avraham Landau of Chekhanov, written by R' Menachem Mendel Chaim Landau from a city Zawiercie in Poland.

The first is based on two פסוקים in אשרי, which are: שומר ה' את כל רצון יראיו יעשה ואת שונעתם ישמע ויושיעם: שומר ה' את כל רצון יראיו יעשה ואת שונעתם ישמע ויושיעם. He brings down a fascinating הארה which after you hear it you say, why didn't I think of that? It says for the יראים, those who fear Hashem, Hashem does their רצון שונעתם ישמע ויושיעם; רצון שונעתם ישמע ויושיעם - Hashem hears them and saves them from their צרות. However, שומר ה' את כל אהביו - the ones who love Hashem, Hashem watches over them that their צרות should not come on them in the first place. So the שמירה that Hashem provides for those who love Him is definitely on a much higher מדרגה than the ones who fear Him. יראת שמים is not a small thing, it's something to aspire to. However, let's first discuss the idea of אהביו, that הקדוש ברוך הוא loves us and we love הקדוש ברוך הוא.

The Ruzhiner Rebbe, quoted in the sefer חיים שיש בהם, has an interesting take on a Gemara which we all know, and he applies it to שמייני עצרת. It's brought down in the Gemara שבת ל"א ע"א that a goy came to גר and said to him, גיירני על מנת שתלמדני כל התורה פולה כשאני עומד על רגל אחת, and said to him, I'm willing to become a גר on the condition that you teach me the whole תורה על רגל אחת. הלל replied with the famous line, דעלקה סני - תורה על רגל אחת. הלל. The Ruzhiner has a completely different take on this Gemara. He points out that the תורה brings the basis for every single יום טוב that we have. There's one יום טוב for which that is not the case, and that's שמייני עצרת. The תורה doesn't give us any טעם, doesn't give us any reason whatsoever as to what this יום טוב is, and we only know about שמייני עצרת's significance from the מדרש. That's what the גר was asking הלל. This גר apparently was already fairly well-versed. He said, "Every יום טוב in the תורה has a reason, אחת, על רגל אחת, כשאני עומד על רגל אחת, except this one רגל." Which רגל is that? That רגל is שמייני עצרת. That's called רגל בפני עצמו, we make a שמייני עצרת. What did הלל answer him? דעלקה סני לחברך לא מעביד - The reason for this יום טוב is to remove the separation between Yidden. It should be a time where we all become one nation of אהבה, אהבה and חיבה between every single Jew and his friend. That's why הקדוש ברוך הוא says, קשה עלי פרידתכם, Just as הקדוש ברוך הוא loves each and every one of us, he wants each and every one of us to love each other.

Now, a vort from R' Meir'l of Premishlan שמתח תורה, also brought down in חיים שיש בהם. One year, at this time of the year, R' Meir'l's daughter became gravely ill. When שמחת תורה came, she was actually closer to מיתה than חיים. However, R' Meir'l's עבודה was unchanged. Exactly as he did every other year he was שמח בשמחת תורה as if there was nothing wrong, as if everything was completely fine. The חסידים came running to him and they said, "Go look what's going on, see what her מצב is." He went into her room, took a look at her situation, came out, and made the following proclamation: "ריבונו של עולם, you told us to be תוקע בשופר ראש השנה on תוקע השנה - Meir'l was תוקע. [He always spoke about himself in the third person]. You told us to be מתענה, to fast on יום כיפור - Meir'l fasted. You told us to sit in the סוכה on סוכות - Meir'l did that too. You also told us to be משמח on שמחת תורה, and Meir'l is having the שמחה. But you made Meir'l's daughter sick. And Meir'l has to be מקבל this situation בשמחה, as חז"ל say (ברכות נ"ד ע"א), חייב אדם לקבל על הרעה פנים שמי שחש על הטובה - The same way that a person is שמח when Hashem showers him with ברכה והצלחה, he has to have exactly the same שמחה when a misfortune befalls him. So Meir'l is מקבל all of this בשמחה. But ריבונו של עולם, I have a שאלה for you. There is a הלכה פסוקה אין מערבין שמחה בין שמחה של יום טוב and a שמחה of being מקבל the situation of my daughter?" They noticed that his daughter immediately began perspiring profusely, and a little while came back to her full state of health.

The last words of this דבר תורה are: רָצוֹן יִרְאוּ יַעֲשֶׂה. רִצּוֹן is not a little thing. We want to have that level of being רָצוֹן. But let's also work very hard to be מקבֵּל on ourselves יִרְאוּ. We should work



very diligently to understand that everything comes from Hashem. We should respect that and treat הקדוש
ברוך הוא with the awesomeness He is worthy of.

